

# DIVERSITY, EQUITY, AND INCLUSION STATEMENT

Kyei Baffour Afari (kafari@unmc.edu)

As an international student and a person of color in biostatistics, I do not think of diversity and inclusion as abstract ideas; they are part of my daily experience. I still remember sitting in graduate seminars in the United States, often one of very few international students or students of color in the room, weighing whether a question I wanted to ask would be heard as curiosity or as evidence that I did not belong. That hesitation is not unique to me; it is the quiet tax that underrepresentation places on people who are already working twice as hard to feel at home in a discipline. I carry the memory of it into every classroom I teach, not as a grievance but as information: it tells me exactly where students lose confidence, and exactly where a small, deliberate act by a teacher can change the trajectory of a student's relationship with the field. Statistics and biostatistics, like many quantitative fields, still struggle with representation. I am committed to doing my part to build a discipline in which students and scholars from all backgrounds feel that they belong and that their perspectives materially improve the science.

My approach to equity rests on a simple conviction: inclusion is not a value you announce; it is a set of practices you build into the ordinary mechanics of a course. The most consequential barriers students face are rarely dramatic. They are the student who has the right answer but will not risk saying it aloud, the student who understands the concept but freezes on the one assessment format the course happens to use, the first-generation student who assumes office hours are for other people. Because these barriers are ordinary, the remedies must be ordinary and structural too, so that they help every student in the room rather than only the ones who know to ask. In my teaching I use anonymous in-class polling so that students who are hesitant to speak publicly can still contribute their reasoning and see that it was correct, which is often the moment a quiet student begins to believe they belong. I use collaborative review tools so that students with different learning styles have more than one route into the material. I deliberately offer assessments in several formats, including problem sets, coding labs, short written reflections, and collaborative projects, not to lower expectations but to ensure that a student's grade reflects their statistical understanding rather than their fluency with a single mode of demonstrating it. I design groups with intention, composing teams that bring together students from different backgrounds, because I have seen repeatedly how much students learn from peers whose path to the same problem differed from their own. My evaluations consistently reflect that students feel respected, encouraged, and supported, and I take that as evidence that inclusivity and rigor are not in tension: students reason more ambitiously when they are confident their voice will be taken seriously.

I am especially attentive to first-generation and international students, because I have been both. Students who are the first in their families to attend university are often less likely to seek help, not because they need it less, but because they are not certain it is available to them, and a single discouraging interaction can confirm a fear they already carried. I therefore treat access as something I must actively extend rather than passively offer. I state explicitly and repeatedly that office hours are for everyone; I normalize asking questions by modeling uncertainty in my own reasoning at the board; and I reach out to students who are struggling before they reach out to me, since the students who most need support are frequently the least likely to request it. One lesson I have learned, through both being mentored and mentoring others, is that good support requires listening before advising. Every student's barriers are different; effective mentorship means understanding a specific person's situation rather than assuming their challenges fit a familiar pattern. I bring that discipline of listening to every advising relationship I take on.

This commitment extends beyond my own classroom into the institutional work of building communities where students feel they belong. At the University of Nebraska Medical Center I served as Treasurer of the College of Public Health Student Association, where I managed the association's budget and helped organize events that brought together graduate students from diverse backgrounds across the college. That role gave me a close, practical view of how community-building at the graduate level shapes whether students believe they have a place in a program, and it deepened my conviction that belonging is produced by sustained institutional effort, not by good intentions alone. I have also mentored students from underrepresented groups directly, helping them navigate the unwritten expectations of graduate study and access research and professional opportunities that are easy to miss without someone pointing the way. As a faculty member I intend to make this work explicit rather than incidental: through structured mentoring, transparent expectations, and active recruitment of students who do not yet see themselves in quantitative research.

My research itself carries an equity dimension that I regard as central rather than incidental. The health problems I study — environmental chemical exposures and their effects on disease outcomes — do not fall equally across communities. Rural communities, agricultural workers, and lower-income populations often bear a disproportionate share of environmental health burdens, yet they are frequently underrepresented in the data and underserved by the methods used to analyze it. When a statistical model is too coarse or too unstable to detect a localized health effect, the communities that disappear first are the ones with the least power to demand that the analysis be done better. Developing scalable methods that can reliably detect these effects, and applying them to surveillance data that captures

how exposure is distributed across communities, is part of how my methodological work contributes to environmental justice in concrete terms. Good statistics in service of the communities that bear the heaviest burdens is not a secondary concern in my research; it is one of the reasons I do it.

I believe a discipline is strongest when it draws on the widest range of perspectives, and that the institutions producing the next generation of statisticians have a responsibility to widen, not narrow, who gets to do this work. I am committed to advancing this through inclusive classrooms that build equity into their ordinary structure, through mentorship that listens before it advises, through institutional service that makes belonging a sustained practice, and through research that keeps the most burdened communities visible in the data. I look forward to contributing to an academic environment that is at once intellectually rigorous and genuinely inclusive, in the conviction that these two commitments do not compete — they reinforce each other.